FOR TWO DECADES NOW, the million or so residents of Dharavi, one of the largest slum clusters in the world, have dreamt of a life of greater dignity—of owning a house, not having to wait in long queues for water and using public toilets, escaping the gutter-lined streets and the poverty and disease. It was back in February 2004 that the first action plan for the redevelopment of Dharavi—one whose blue tarpaulined hutments have defined the gritty Mumbai skyline in many a film—as an integrated planned township was drawn up by the state government.

In 18 years, at least three attempts (in 2007, 2016 and 2018) to invite bids to redevelop Dharavi fell through. So, when in November last year an Adani Group company stepped in and won the bid that covers 645 acres of prime land in central Mumbai, it was no small feat. And yet, barely months later, uncertainty looms again, with concerns being raised about how the Adani Group company won the contract, the financial capability of the group to execute the project as it tries to ride out the Hindenburg controversy and, whether it is seeing the project as a resettlement plan or a real estate goldmine.

Dharavi residents have grown sceptical of the resettlement plan, which is expected to take almost two decades to complete. Not only that, the opposition Congress has accused the government of favouritism, stating the project's bidding conditions were changed to exclude a previous successful bidder and help the Adani Group win the tender at a much lower price.

In 2019, the UAE-based Seclink Technologies Corp., which offered Rs 7,200 crore against Adani Properties' Rs 4,539 crore, had emerged as the highest bidder. But the state government decided to include a 45-acre plot belonging to the railways for the rehabilitation of the slum-dwellers. Since the scope of the project had changed, fresh bids were invited and tenders floated again in October 2022. While Seclink has now moved the Bombay High Court (the case is being heard), Congress leader Jairam Ramesh has questioned whether Prime Minister Narendra Modi forced the Maharashtra government to change the tender conditions to deliberately exclude the original winner and "once again help his favourite business group". Adani Properties had bagged the project in the second tender with a Rs 5,069 crore bid last year, Rs 2,131 crore less than Seclink's original winning bid.

However, despite the state cabinet deciding to award the project to Adani Properties, the state is yet to issue a government resolution (GR) formalising it. In the budget session in March this year, deputy chief minister Devendra Fadnavis told the legislative assembly that the letter of intent (LoI) would be issued after the urban development department grants a pending approval. Valsa Nair Singh, additional chief secretary (housing), denies that there are any delays. "The final GR will be issued soon after the line departments issue GRs for the concessions approved by the cabinet," she says. After the GR, the state government will issue an LoI, followed by the inking of the MoU and the formation of a special purpose vehicle (SPV), with the developer and government holding an 80 per cent and 20 per cent stake, respectively.

HAVING WAITED SO LONG, DHARAVI RESIDENTS ARE SCEPTICAL OF THE RESETTLEMENT PLAN, WHICH IS EXPECTED TO TAKE ALMOST 20 YEARS

Not everyone buys these assurances, though. "We are not against development, but in the wake of the recent controversy, we doubt whether Adani will be able to execute the project," says former MLA and Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) leader Baburao Mane. Mane is part of the Dharavi Bachao Andolan (DBA), an umbrella front of opposition parties and voluntary groups. The DBA wants Adani Properties out or, at the very least, safeguards like stiff penalty clauses to prevent time overruns.

A REAL ESTATE JACKPOT

A stone's throw from the Bandra Kurla Complex (BKC), an upscale business district in the city, Dharavi is a land of opportunities in a space-starved city. Multiple railheads like the Mahim, Bandra, GTB Nagar, Kings Circle and Matunga Road stations, the under-construction metro railway project, the arterial eastern and western expressways, the international airport are all easy to access from here. Not just that, Dharavi itself, with its thriving leather processing units and tanneries, scrap recycling units and home-run businesses, is now one of the biggest informal industrial hubs in India.

The living conditions, however, can boast of no such distinction. Around 400,000 people live cheek by jowl per square kilometre here, compared to a population density of around 27,000 people per sq. km for the rest of Mumbai. A public toilet seat in the neighbourhood is shared, on average, by around 250 people daily. These conditions contributed, in no small measure, to the slum emerging as an infection hotspot during the Covid-19 pandemic.

The urban renewal project is a much-needed step in that sense. Under it, the residents of Dharavi will get flats with a minimum carpet area of 405 sq. ft. The area will